

CLEFT SENTENCES



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- *A **cleft sentence** is a sentence structure used to **focus or emphasize one particular part of a sentence** by dividing one simple sentence into two clauses. The word **cleft** means **split or divided**.*
 - Normal sentence - Tom bought the car yesterday.
 - Cleft sentence - **It was Tom who bought the car yesterday.**
- *The information is the same, but the cleft sentence emphasizes **Tom**.*



Why do we use cleft sentences?

- We use cleft sentences to:
 - emphasize a person
 - emphasize a thing
 - emphasize time
 - emphasize place
 - emphasize reason
 - emphasize an action
 - correct wrong information
 - compare or contrast information
- make speech or writing more natural and dramatic



Main Types of Cleft Sentences

- There are **six major types**.

1. **It-cleft** - **it be + emphasized part + wh...+ rest of sentence**
2. **Wh-cleft** - **Wh... + clause + be + emphasized information**
3. **Reversed Wh-cleft** - **Emphasized information + be + what-clause**
4. **All-cleft** - **All + clause + be + emphasized information**
5. **Inferential (Reason) clefts** - **It + be+ because + S + V + that + S + V**
6. **The thing/person/place that...**



IT-CLEFT (Most Common)

- It + be + emphasized part + who/that/which + rest of sentence
- Emphasizing a Person
 - **Normal**: Sarah won the prize.
 - **Cleft**: It was Sarah who won the prize.
 - **Normal**: Jack broke the window.
 - **Cleft**: It was Jack who broke the window.
 - **Normal**: My father cooked dinner.
 - **Cleft**: It was my father who cooked dinner.



IT CLEFT SENTENCES

- **Emphasizing a Thing**

- **Normal:** She bought a laptop.
- **Cleft:** It was a laptop that she bought.
- **Normal:** They need more money.
- **Cleft:** It is more money that they need.

- **Emphasizing Time**

- **Normal:** He arrived yesterday.
- **Cleft:** It was yesterday that he arrived.
- **Normal:** We met in June.
- **Cleft:** It was in June that we met.



IT CLEFT SENTENCES

▪ Emphasizing Place

- **Normal:** They found the keys in the kitchen.
- **Cleft:** *It was in the kitchen that they found the keys.*

▪ Emphasizing Reason

- **Normal:** She left because she was tired.
- **Cleft:** *It was because she was tired that she left.*

▪ Emphasizing a Whole Clause

- **Normal:** She forgot to call me.
- **Cleft:** *It was that she forgot to call me that upset me.*



Tense in It-clefts

- *The verb **be** changes according to the tense.*
- **Present:** It is John who helps me.
- **Past:** It was John who helped me.
- **Future:** It will be John who helps me.
- **Present Perfect:** It has been John who has helped me.



Relative Pronouns

- **After a person** - Usually: **who** Sometimes: **that** ishlatiladi

- Examples

- It was Anna **who** called.
- It was Anna **that** called.

- **After things** - Usually: **that** Sometimes: **which** ishlatiladi

- Examples

- It was the book **that** I lost.
- It was the book **which** I lost.



WH-CLEFT (Pseudo-cleft)

- **What + clause + be + emphasized information**
- *This focuses on the **important information at the end**.*
- **Normal:** I need a holiday. **Wh-cleft:** What I need is a holiday.
- **Normal:** She wants a new phone. **Wh-cleft:** What she wants is a new phone.
- **Normal:** They bought a new car. **Wh-cleft:** What they bought was a new car.
- **Normal:** I enjoy reading. **Wh-cleft:** What I enjoy is reading.
- **Normal:** We need more time. **Wh-cleft:** What we need is more time.



Other WH-words

- *Although **what** is the most common, other WH-words are also possible.*

- **Where**

- Where we met was the library.

- **When**

- When I feel happiest is during the holidays.

- **Why**

- Why he resigned is still unclear.

- **How**

- How she solved the problem was amazing.



REVERSED WH-CLEFT

- **Emphasized information + be + what-clause**

- **Normal:** I need a holiday.

- **Reversed:** A holiday is what I need.

- **Examples**

- More sleep is what you need.

- A new car is what they bought.

- Peace is what everyone wants.

- Success is what he dreams about.



ALL-CLEFT

- All + clause + be + emphasized information

- *This means **the only thing**.*

- **Examples**

- All I want is peace. – The only thing that I want is peace.
- All she needs is rest.
- All we did was wait.
- All they asked for was help.
- All he wanted was some advice.

- **Notice**

- All I did was apologize. = I only apologized.



THE THING / THE PERSON / THE PLACE THAT...

- *Instead of "what" we can use them*
- The thing that surprised me was his answer.
- = What surprised me was his answer.
- The person who helped me was John.
- The place where we met was Paris.
- The reason why she left was obvious.
- The day when we met changed my life.



INFERENCEAL (Reason) CLEFTS

- *Used to explain or infer a reason.*
- **It + be + because + S + V + that + S + V**
 - **It's because he was tired** that he fell asleep.
 - **It's because of the weather** that the match was cancelled.
- **The reason (why) + S + V + is (that) + S + V / noun**
 - The reason **why he fell asleep** was **that he was tired**.
 - The reason **why the match as cancelled** was **the weather**.
 - The reason **why they moved** is **that they found a better job**.



Emphasizing Different Parts

- **Tom** bought a new laptop yesterday in London because he needed it.
- **Person**: It was Tom who bought a new laptop yesterday.
- **Thing**: It was a new laptop that Tom bought yesterday.
- **Time**: It was yesterday that Tom bought a new laptop.
- **Place**: It was in London that Tom bought a new laptop.
- **Reason**: It was because he needed it that Tom bought a new laptop.
- **Action**: what Tom did yesterday in London **was to buy a new laptop.**



Common Mistakes

- ❌ **Wrong** - It is John **which** helped me.
- ✅ **Correct** - It is John **who** helped me.
- ❌ **Wrong** - What I need **are** a car.
- ✅ **Correct** - What I need **is** a car.
- (Although in informal English, "are" is sometimes heard with plural complements.)
- ❌ **Wrong** - It was **because tired** she left.
- ✅ **Correct** - It was **because she** was tired that she left.
- ❌ **Wrong** - What I bought **it was** a phone.
- ✅ **Correct** - What I bought **was** a phone.



Cleft vs Fronting

- *Fronting simply moves information to the front.*
 - **Fronting**: Yesterday, I met Sarah.
 - **Cleft**: It was yesterday that I met Sarah.
- *A cleft sentence gives **stronger emphasis** than fronting.*
- **Cleft vs Passive** - *Passive changes the focus to the receiver of the action.*
 - **Active**: Tom repaired the car.
 - **Passive**: The car was repaired by Tom.
 - **Cleft**: It was Tom who repaired the car.
- *Passive focuses on **the car**, while the cleft focuses on **Tom**.*



Type	Structure	Example
It-cleft	It + be + focus + who/that + clause	It was Sarah who called.
Wh-cleft	What + clause + be + focus	What I need is sleep.
Reversed Wh-cleft	Focus + be + what-clause	Sleep is what I need.
All-cleft	All + clause + be + focus	All I want is peace.
Thing/Person cleft	The thing/person/place + relative clause + be + focus	The thing that matters is honesty.
Reason cleft	It + be + because... + that + clause	It was because he was tired that he left.